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Update**

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Highlights from Expert Call

We hosted a call on Friday with Aran Khanna, CEO of Archera, which is a high growth company advising customers on \$5.5bn+ in annual cloud consumption spend. Herein we share high level takeaways from the call.

Archera Background. Having worked as an AI Engineer at both AWS and Azure, Mr. Khanna co-founded Archera to help customers in planning and optimizing their cloud spend. The company offers an automation-first, quantitative approach to cloud resource management and provides customers with insurance against their committed cloud forecasts. Archera regularly helps its customers save 30% or more on their cloud consumption costs.

Cloud Budget Trends by Customer Segment: Archera segments its customer base as does AWS, across Enterprise, ISVs/Digital Natives, SMBs/Startups and AI focused. We touch on trends for several of these:

- **Enterprise** commitment growth continues to be fueled primarily by a sustained velocity of migrations. In addition to chunkier VMware, SAP or analytics workloads, coding agents have started to unlock migration of legacy on-prem systems like mainframes that have historically been viewed as much more sticky and complicated to move. Rising hardware prices were also said to be stretching IT upgrade budgets, pushing some organizations toward instead leasing the capacity in the cloud until budget frees up and/or pricing retreats. Cloud vendors have reportedly helped facilitate this by holding non-AI infrastructure prices relatively flat despite tight supply, making the bet that capturing this real production share will compound in the years to come. AI spending is viewed as still sub-10% of IT spend for most enterprises, but this is net new consumption and increasingly a durable and more predictable budget line item as coding agents are widely adopted within engineering teams (often subject to individual token budgets). Wider enterprise AI roll outs remain gated to a degree by concerns around agentic security and governance. This is leading to some re-litigation of the tech stack as companies try to determine how to deploy agents safely and is manifesting in a growing number of first-time vendors showing up in cloud marketplace transactions among Archera customers.
- **ISVs/Digital Natives** were characterized as the customer segment that has accelerated the most in 2026. Mr. Khanna noted that 3Q marked the third consecutive quarter of acute GPU shortages creating what he described as interesting second and third order effects across the ecosystem. Access to H100s, H200s and other accelerator capacity has

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become more restrictive with hyperscalers increasingly requiring larger resource level commitments in order to secure such capacity. Against this backdrop, mature ISVs and digital natives are increasingly adopting neoclouds as part of their production infrastructure stack, and customers securing initial Rubin capacity are generally not giving up existing Blackwell allocations. Mr. Khanna also highlighted the emergence of "GPU rich" and "GPU poor" companies, noting that access to compute has become a competitive differentiator both for business and for talent.

- **AI-focused** customers' adoption of open weight models expanded in 3Q with Mr. Khanna estimating that roughly three quarters of tokens consumed through major CSP platforms among Archera's AI-focused customers were tied to open weight models serving end user production use cases. Among open models, GLM and Kimi were highlighted as seeing growing adoption, while Jev was cited as a potentially important shift given its different architecture and increasing popularity among browser based agentic applications. While proprietary models continue to command the majority of higher end R&D workloads, Mr. Khanna noted that OpenAI has been taking share within Bedrock and described Codex as having increasingly closed the gap with competing frontier offerings since June. He also noted that AI-focused customers are driving demand for the surrounding infrastructure stack, including observability, object storage, enterprise search, and BYO cloud architectures as production AI apps continue to scale.

Cloud by Cloud

- **AWS (AMZN covered by Ben Black)** NTM committed dollar growth rose from 35% in June to just shy of 38% in September with consumption growth climbing from 38% to 40% over the same period. Mr. Khanna again cited AWS bringing inference capacity online in a steady stair-step fashion to service customer backlog, but like peers remains acutely capacity constrained. AWS was said to be leveraging the tight current environment to strategically push customers toward more expansive, multi-year PPAs to get access to GPU resources, and where possible also its proprietary GPU, CPU and networking hardware. This has apparently led to AWS consistently turning away singularly token based demand from smaller AI Native, Digital Natives and ISVs given capacity constraints in Bedrock, where Mr. Khanna suggested consumption likely tripled again this year as enterprises increasingly procure production tokens through these types of CSP platforms for model flexibility and to stay within the governance boundary of their VPC.
- **Azure** NTM committed dollar growth for Archera's customer base in aggregate was just under 39.5% in September, up from 36.5% in June. This was driven in good part by some larger MACC commitments for Rubin capacity that came through in C3Q, ahead of what is anticipated to be a real ramp in this platform starting in late-C4Q and into C1H27. Azure's strategy still appears to focus on deploying more leading edge SKUs under longer-term contracts with strategic customers, which has led to more limited availability for smaller ISVs and startups. Mr. Khanna also noted an interesting change in their MACC program; starting in January, they are reportedly stopping convertibility of resource



commitments (i.e. fungibility of commit between instance types), which he expects will end up lowering the reserved commitment coverage rate (i.e. greater mix of spot/on-demand) and therefore be accretive to margins. On the consumption side, acceleration was more modest, with growth just shy of 41% in September, up a smaller 1.5pts from 39.5% in June. Among the large CSPs it sounds like Azure is still probably the most constrained in terms of infrastructure availability near-term, in part due to strong demand for its first party SW offerings that were cited as a tailwind in the quarter. Specifically, M365 Copilot attach rates on MACCs reportedly took a big jump y/y, while GitHub Copilot benefited from OAI model share gains in coding and the previously mentioned enterprise focus on governance/sovereignty.

- **GCP (GOOG covered by Ben Black)** NTM committed dollar growth jumped further to 48.5% in September from 45% in June, and consumption growth similarly increased to just over 48% from 45% over the same period. More so than others, GCP appears to have incremental capacity available, attributed to shifting infrastructure from other areas of the business to cloud as opposed to having to wait for a new data center to go live. In some cases, this allows them to deliver capacity within a week or so of taking a commitment and therefore consumption growth is more closely tracking commit growth. GCP is increasingly becoming a second platform for production workloads among ISV and Digital Native customers and also capturing a growing share of spend from AI Natives amid constraints elsewhere. Google custom silicon is also becoming more widely adopted, Ironwood TPUs now being directly sold and deployed in hundreds of GCP customers' and neocloud environments.
- **OCI** committed spend growth among Archera's customers accelerated from 86% in 2Q to ~107% in 3Q, though Mr. Khanna noted that this is against a relatively smaller base vs the other clouds. Usage was cited to be increasingly shifting toward production workloads from what had previously been a relatively inexpensive source of H100 capacity for smaller customers, largely used for R&D. New ISV logos were cited as a key driver with some customers that were unable to secure production capacity at the major CSPs turning to OCI, both for capacity and the surrounding cloud services need to support these workloads. While Mr. Khanna characterized Oracle's software as less mature than that of the larger CSPs, he noted that coding agents are making it easier for customers to deploy on the platform. Existing AI native customers also notably expanded their OCI contracts by ~30-40%. That said, Oracle too remains capacity constrained and has had to turn down some demand, leaving customers to source compute across multiple providers.

Vendor Takes

Mr. Khanna pointed to **Snowflake's** agreement with AWS in 3Q as highly strategic, with secured capacity acting as a moat while supply remains tight, to drive CoCo and broader Cortex suite adoption, including some token resale type activity. **Databricks and Vercel** were also cited as pursuing similar capacity agreements with large providers. Separately, he also characterized the software stack as being "relitigated" as demand emerges for serverless, BYO cloud offerings that he



described as capable of scaling "10x more for half the cost". As an example, he cited that while **Datadog** consumption continues to grow among startups, ISVs and AI natives, some customers are carving off slices of AI observability to run on providers such as **ClickHouse**. Beyond the ISV landscape, Mr. Khanna noted that the frontier labs are pushing customers toward longer term commitments and pointed to **OpenAI's** newly announced marketplace as another way to expand the scope of these relationships, similar to the cloud marketplaces.

From a neocloud perspective, Mr. Khanna highlighted **Cloudflare** and **Nebius** as examples of vendors moving beyond raw GPU infrastructure and building durable value through token-as-a-service offerings. Along similar lines, **Baseten** and **Fireworks AI** were cited as becoming a durable part of production commitments customers were making. Mr. Khanna believes there remains significant margin expansion opportunity for these vendors on the back of workload optimization, batching, and efficient token serving. Supply/demand conditions remain extremely tight with Blackwell pricing cited as high as \$14/GPU hour (35%+ above on-demand list prices earlier in the year) and an active secondary market is emerging to broker unused GPU allocations. Lastly, he noted **CoreWeave** was benefiting from customers willing to pay a premium for access to large scale training clusters, creating a durable market for customers including neolabs.



Appendix 1

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